CAREER DEVELOPMENT CENTER · SNIST

IN COLLABORATION WITH

STUDENTALUMNI.AI

HackWave 3.0 2026

NATIONAL LEVEL · 24-HOUR HACKATHON

Event Handbook

Registration · Tickets · Coupons · Takeaways · Operations

DATES	WINDOW	VENUE	REGISTER
Sep 4 – 5, 2026	Sep 4, 08:00 AM → Sep 5, 01:00 PM	SNIST Campus, Hyderabad	studentalumni.ai/echo/snist

1. At a glance

Event	HackWave 3.0 — 2026
Format	National-level 24-hour hackathon (on-campus, overnight)
Dates	Sep 4th 08:00 AM → Sep 5th 01:00 PM
Venue	SNIST campus, Hyderabad
Hosts	SNIST Career Development Center, in collaboration with StudentAlumni.ai
Registration	`studentalumni.ai/echo/snist`
Prize pool	₹50,000 + partner perks
Special session	Virtual Cyber Security Conclave — ISC2 New Jersey Chapter
Perk partners	Featherless AI · CodeSpectra · StepUpMark AI · Bandiwala · WeHive

2. The journey in one picture



Every step below maps to one arrow in that diagram.

Section A — Participant journey, end to end

A1. Discover

Participant sees the poster / LinkedIn post / campus banner and goes to `studentalumni.ai/echo/snist`.

A2. Register

Fills the registration form (Section B). Solo or team — DECIDE whether team registration is one submission with member details, or each member registers individually and joins a team code. *Recommendation: individual registration + team code.* It keeps every participant's ticket, meals and certificate tied to a real identity, which matters when you're issuing certificates and food coupons per head.

A3. Verify

Email (and optionally phone) verification. Unverified registrations do not receive a ticket.

A4. Ticket issued

On verification the system generates a ticket and places it in **My Tickets** on the SA Dashboard. A copy goes out by email; ASSUMED WhatsApp/SMS also carries a deep link.

A5. Codethon rounds (pre-event)

The Codethon runs **before** the event and **closes before it goes live**: L1 → L2 → L3 on CodeSpectra, each level scored. Results update the participant's ticket status (`L1 attempted` → `L1 cleared` → `L2` → `L3`), so the same ticket carries their progress. Codethon winners are decided on level reached and score, and are recognised at the main event. The hackathon rules in Sections K–P do not apply to this track.

A6. Arrive and check in

Volunteer scans the QR at the entry desk. Ticket flips to `Checked In`. Wristband issued.

A7. During the event

The same ticket QR is scanned for each meal slot and for session attendance. Each scan is recorded once and only once per slot.

A8. Close and collect

Certificates, partner coupons and any prizes are released to My Tickets after the closing ceremony. Coupons remain in the dashboard permanently, or until each partner's expiry.

A9. The full programme — eight items

Eight items make up the programme. Seven run inside the 24 hours; **the Codethon runs before the event and closes before it goes live**, which makes it structurally different from everything else here.

The pre-event track

Item	When	Outcome
Codethon (L1 · L2 · L3)	Opens ahead of the event, **closes before Sep 4**	Winners decided on score by level; goodies for top performers

Why this matters to the build. The Codethon is a separate event object in the system, not a session inside HackWave. Consequences:

- **Its own registration and its own close date**, earlier than the main event's. Someone can enter the Codethon without attending HackWave, and vice versa. DECIDE — is Codethon entry restricted to HackWave registrants, or open to anyone?
- **Its own ticket** in My Tickets, with status reflecting level progress (`L1 attempted` → `L1 cleared` → `L2` → `L3`) rather than check-in state.
- **Scores are the ranking mechanism.** Level reached first, score within level second. Store both; publish the tie-break rule before L1 opens, or you'll be arguing about it afterwards.
- **Results must be final before HackWave goes live**, since winners are recognised at the main event. Build in a buffer between the Codethon close and Sep 4 for score verification and dispute handling.
- **Goodies are a separate reward set** from the HackWave perks (Section F) and unlock on Codethon results, not on event check-in.

Inside the 24 hours

#	Item	What it is	Scanned?
1	**Build by Sunset**	Ship something real between morning and dusk — the core build block	No (continuous)
2	**Voices That Build**	The panel — people who have actually shipped	Yes
3	**Meet the People Who Hire**	Recruiters in the room, not behind a portal	Yes — attendance matters to partners
4	**Between the Builds**	Rest, food, working space, finding people. Open both days	No (meal scans cover it)
5	**Play After Dark**	Live music when the laptops finally close	No
6	**Build by Fireside**	Where the idea you haven't shipped yet gets heard	Yes
7	**International Panel Discussion**	Speakers joining live on the big screen from outside India	Yes
+	**Virtual Cyber Security Conclave**	ISC2 New Jersey Chapter — trends, certifications, career pathways	Yes — needed if certificates are issued for it

DECIDE Whether session attendance affects anything (certificate wording, eligibility for a partner perk), or is recorded for reporting only. If it affects nothing, don't scan it — every scan station needs a volunteer standing at it.

Codethon timeline ASSUMED *set real dates*

Milestone	Timing
Codethon registration opens	With the main campaign
L1 window	Ahead of the event
L2 window	After L1 results
L3 / final level	Closes with a buffer before Sep 4
Scores verified, disputes closed	Before results publish
Results published to My Tickets	Before HackWave goes live
Winners recognised, goodies released	At the HackWave closing ceremony

A10. What students take away

This is the answer to "what do I actually get out of showing up", and it should appear on the registration page, not only in the confirmation email.

Guaranteed for every checked-in participant

Takeaway	Delivered as	When
Participation certificate	PDF in My Tickets + email, with a verification URL	After closing
Meals across the event	6 coupon slots on the ticket	Live during event
Bandiwala coupon	Code in My Tickets → Rewards	At check-in
WeHive coupon	Code in My Tickets → Rewards	At check-in
CodeSpectra access	Code in My Tickets → Rewards	After closing
Recruiter exposure	In person — "Meet the People Who Hire"	During event
Mentorship	In person, through the build block	During event
Permanent participation record	The ticket stays in My Tickets forever	Immediately

For Codethon winners (decided before the event)

Takeaway	Who
Goodies / merchandise	Top performers by level and score
Codethon winner certificate	Top three per level DECIDE
Recognition at the closing ceremony	Announced on stage at HackWave
Level + score on record	Everyone who attempts, visible in My Tickets

For HackWave qualifiers and winners

Takeaway	Who
Featherless AI credits + Premium access	Per MoU tier — CONFIRM
StepUpMark AI credits	Per MoU — CONFIRM
Prize pool share (₹50,000)	Top three
Winner certificate	Top three

Design note. Everything in these two tables should land in the same place — My Tickets → Rewards — rather than being split across email, WhatsApp and a Google Drive folder. One destination is what makes the takeaways feel real rather than promised.

Section B — Registration

B1. Form fields

Required

Field	Notes
Full name	As it should appear on the certificate
Email	Verification target; certificate delivery
Mobile number	Day-of contact, WhatsApp updates
College / institution	Free text + autocomplete
Branch / department	
Year of study	Dropdown
Roll number / student ID	Required for SNIST students; used for campus verification
Participation type	Solo · Team member · Team lead
Team name / team code	Team lead creates, members join with the code
Dietary preference	Veg / Non-veg / Jain / Vegan — drives food counts
Consent checkboxes	T&C, media release, partner data sharing (see G)

Optional

Skills/stack tags · GitHub or portfolio link · LinkedIn URL · Previous hackathon experience · Accessibility or medical needs the organisers should know about (free text, handled confidentially)

B2. Validation rules

- One registration per email; one per phone number.
- One registration per college roll number, to stop duplicate ticket farming.
- **Hackathon team size: minimum 2, maximum 5 members.** Enforce this at team-code join time, not after the fact.
- Registration closes DECIDE — recommend 48 hours before start so catering and kits can be counted; keep a small on-desk walk-in quota.
- Capacity cap with automatic waitlist once full.

B3. Confirmation

On successful verification the participant receives:

1. **In-dashboard**: ticket appears in My Tickets.
2. **Email**: confirmation with the QR image attached, event address, timings, what to bring, and the link back to My Tickets.
3. **Calendar file** (.ics) so the dates land in their calendar.

> **Design note.** Email the QR as an *attached PNG*, not only as an inline image. Many mail clients block remote images by default, and a participant standing at the gate with no signal needs the code already on their device.

Section C — The ticket

C1. What the QR actually contains

Do **not** encode personal data in the QR. Encode a short signed token; everything else is looked up server-side at scan time.

```
Payload (signed, e.g. JWT or HMAC token):
{
  "t":  "HW3-2026",          // event id
  "u":  "a91f4c0e",          // opaque participant id, not the email
  "tk": "TKT-000482",        // ticket id
  "v":  1,                   // token version
  "exp": 1757088000          // expiry, a few hours past event end
}
Signature: HMAC-SHA256 over the payload with a server-side secret.
```

Why this shape:

- **No PII in the code.** A photographed QR reveals nothing about the person.
- **Signed.** A forged QR fails signature validation offline, without a database round-trip.
- **Versioned.** Bumping `v` invalidates every previously issued code if you ever need to reissue en masse.

C2. Ticket states

State	Set when	Visible to participant as
`PENDING`	Form submitted, not verified	"Verify your email to get your ticket"
`ACTIVE`	Verified	"Ready — show this at the gate"
`WAITLISTED`	Over capacity	"You're on the waitlist"
`CHECKED_IN`	Gate scan on day 1	"Checked in ✓"
`COMPLETED`	Closing ceremony	"Completed — certificate available"
`CANCELLED`	Participant cancels or is removed	"Cancelled"
`NO_SHOW`	Never scanned at gate	(shown internally only)

C3. My Tickets — SA Dashboard

Location: `Dashboard → My Tickets`

List view. Each ticket is a card: event logo, event name, date, venue, status pill, and a thumbnail of the QR. Upcoming events sort above past ones. Past tickets stay forever — they double as a participation record.

Detail view. Tapping a ticket opens:

1. **QR block** — large, high contrast, screen brightness boosted automatically on mobile. Below it, the ticket ID in plain text as a fallback if a scanner fails.
2. **Event essentials** — date, reporting time, venue with a map link, what to bring.
3. **Meal coupons strip** — one chip per meal slot, each showing `Available` / `Used at 13:42` / `Expired`. (Section E.)
4. **Rewards & takeaways** — partner coupons and certificate, unlocked after the event. (Section F.)
5. **Team panel** — team name, code, members, L1/L2/L3 progress.
6. **Actions** — Add to Wallet DECIDE, Download PDF, Add to Calendar, Cancel registration.

Offline behaviour. Cache the QR and the essentials locally. Campus wifi under load is exactly where this breaks, and a ticket that needs a network call to render is a ticket that fails at the gate.

C4. Anti-abuse

- **One active scan session.** A ticket already `CHECKED_IN` cannot be checked in again; the scanner shows the earlier timestamp and the participant's name and photo DECIDE *photo capture at registration?*.
- **Rotating QR (optional).** Regenerating the visual code every 30–60 seconds inside the app defeats screenshot sharing. Worth it for meals; probably overkill for gate entry. DECIDE
- **Rate limiting** on the scan endpoint per device.

Section D — Check-in and on-ground scanning

D1. Scanner app

Volunteers use a web-based scanner (`studentalumni.ai/scan` , phone camera, no install) logged in with a **volunteer role** account. Each scan station is set to a **mode** before the session starts:

`GATE_ENTRY` · `MEAL_<slot>` · `SESSION_<name>` · `EXIT`

The mode determines what a scan does. A volunteer cannot accidentally consume a lunch coupon at the entry gate because the station isn't in that mode.

D2. Scan result screen

Big, colour-coded, readable at arm's length in daylight:

- **Green — Valid.** Name, college, team, and what was just consumed.

- **Amber — Already used.** Shows when and at which station.
- **Red — Invalid.** Bad signature, wrong event, cancelled ticket.

D3. Offline fallback

Before the event, each scanner device downloads a signed allowlist of valid ticket IDs. If the network drops, scans validate against that cached list and queue locally, syncing when connectivity returns. Duplicate detection reconciles on sync.

> This is the single most important resilience decision in the whole system. A hackathon gate with 300 students queuing and no network is a predictable event, not an edge case.

D4. Manual fallback

Volunteers can search by name, email or ticket ID and check a participant in manually. Every manual check-in is logged with the volunteer's ID.

Section E — Food coupons

E1. Slots ASSUMED *confirm against your catering plan*

Five slots. **There is no Day 2 closing lunch** — the event ends at 01:00 PM and participants leave from the closing ceremony.

#	Slot	Window	Notes
1	Day 1 — Lunch	Sep 4, 12:30–14:00	
2	Day 1 — Evening snacks	Sep 4, 17:00–18:00	
3	Day 1 — Dinner	Sep 4, 20:00–21:30	
4	Overnight — Midnight refuel	Sep 5, 00:30–02:00	Tea/coffee, light bites
5	Day 2 — Breakfast	Sep 5, 07:30–09:00	

E2. How they work

- Coupons are **not separate QR codes**. The participant's single ticket QR is scanned at a station running in `MEAL_<slot>` mode. Fewer things to lose, nothing to print.
- Each slot can be consumed **once per ticket**. A second attempt shows amber with the original timestamp.
- Slots open and close on the clock. Outside the window, the station refuses with a clear message rather than silently consuming the coupon.

- Dietary preference from registration is shown on the scan result so the counter hands over the right meal.

E3. Food stalls

Alongside the included meal slots, **food stalls are available on site**. These are a separate, paid channel — participants buy directly from the stall, and stalls are not tied to the ticket QR.

- Publish stall locations and opening hours with the schedule, especially overnight.
- Meal coupons apply only at the designated counters, not at the stalls. Say this clearly at registration, or the desk will spend the event answering it.
- Stalls also cover the gap left by removing the Day 2 closing lunch.
- DECIDE Whether any partner or sponsor coupon is redeemable at the stalls.

E4. Counter operations

- Two to three scan stations per counter at peak; queue splits by dietary preference, not alphabetically.
- Live count in the organiser dashboard: consumed vs. registered per slot, so catering can be topped up before it runs out rather than after.
- **Guests, judges, mentors, volunteers** need tickets too — issue them non-participant tickets so their meals are counted. DECIDE whether these are visible in the same My Tickets UI.

Section F — Partner coupons and takeaways

F1. What participants receive

Partner	Offer	Eligibility CONFIRM *WITH EACH PARTNER*
Featherless AI	Credits + Premium access	Per MoU — confirm tier and duration
CodeSpectra	Free access period	All participants / finalists
StepUpMark AI	Credits	*(Note: your MoU spells this SetupMark AI — one spelling is wrong, please confirm)*
Bandiwala	Discount coupon	All checked-in participants
WeHive	Discount coupon	All checked-in participants
SNIST × SA	Participation certificate	All checked-in participants
SNIST × SA	Winner certificates + prize	Top three

F2. Redemption models — pick one per partner

Model 1 — Unique code (preferred). The partner supplies a batch of one-time codes. Your system assigns one code per eligible participant and shows it in My Tickets with a "Copy code" button and a "Redeem at partner →" link. *Pros:* per-person tracking, no leakage. *Cons:* needs a code batch from each partner, and a low-stock alert.

Model 2 — Shared code. One code for everyone (`HACKWAVE3`). Simple, zero integration. *Cons:* it will be shared publicly within hours. Only acceptable for low-value offers.

Model 3 — Referral link. A tracked URL per participant. Works when the partner can attribute at signup.

Model 4 — API issuance. Your backend calls the partner's API at unlock time and stores the returned code. Cleanest for participants, most integration effort.

> **Recommendation.** Model 1 for Featherless AI, CodeSpectra and StepUpMark AI (real monetary value, worth tracking). Model 3 or 1 for Bandiwala and WeHive. Avoid Model 2 for anything you'd be unhappy seeing posted in a public Telegram group.

F3. The redirect flow

```
My Tickets → Rewards → [Partner card] → "Redeem"
       │
       ├─ Code is revealed + copied to clipboard
       │
       └─ Opens partner URL in a new tab:
          https://partner.example.com/redeem
            ?code=HW3-AB12-CD34
            &utm_source=studentalumni
            &utm_medium=hackwave3
            &utm_campaign=snist_2026
            &ref=<opaque_participant_id>
```

Three rules for this flow:

1. **Never auto-redirect.** Show the code on your page first. If the partner site is down or the participant closes the tab, they haven't lost the code.
2. **Log the click.** Store `redeemed_at` when they tap. This is the number partners will ask you for after the event.
3. **New tab, not same tab.** The participant should land back on their dashboard, not have to navigate back.

F4. Unlock timing DECIDE

Option	Effect
At registration	Maximum reach, but people can register only to farm coupons
At check-in	Ties rewards to actual attendance — **recommended**
At closing	Encourages people to stay to the end

A sensible split: Bandiwala and WeHive coupons unlock **at check-in** (they're a perk of showing up); AI platform credits and certificates unlock **at closing**.

F5. Certificates

- Generated as PDF with the participant's name, event name, dates, and a verification ID.
- Delivered to My Tickets → Rewards, and by email.
- Include a **verification URL** (`studentalumni.ai/verify/<id>`) so a recruiter can confirm the certificate is real. This is the feature that makes the certificate worth something.
- DECIDE Do certificates require check-in? *Recommend yes — a participation certificate for someone who never attended devalues every other one.*

Section G — Terms and conditions

The following is participant-facing copy. Have it reviewed by SNIST before publishing; it is written to be readable, not to substitute for legal review.

1. Eligibility

HackWave 3.0 is open to students currently enrolled in a recognised institution. Participants may be asked to show a valid student ID at check-in. Registration is personal and non-transferable.

2. Registration and tickets

Registration is complete only after email verification. Each ticket is issued to one named individual and is valid only for that person. Tickets, QR codes and coupons may not be sold, shared, resold or reproduced. Organisers may cancel any ticket found to be duplicated, transferred or obtained through false information.

3. Attendance

Participants must check in at the registration desk on arrival. This is an overnight event on campus; participants remaining overnight agree to follow campus rules and the instructions of organisers and security staff throughout. Participants under 18 require written consent from a parent or guardian.

4. Food coupons

Meal entitlements are included with registration and are redeemed by scanning your event ticket at the designated counter within the published time window for each meal. Each meal may be claimed once per participant. Unclaimed meals are not carried forward, exchanged or refunded. Dietary preferences are catered for as indicated at registration on a best-effort basis.

5. Partner offers and coupons

Offers provided by partners (including Featherless AI, CodeSpectra, StepUpMark AI, Bandiwala and WeHive) are supplied by those partners and are subject to each partner's own terms, availability and expiry dates. StudentAlumni.ai and SNIST facilitate distribution but are not responsible for the fulfilment, quality or continued availability of any partner offer. Coupons have no cash value and cannot be exchanged.

6. Intellectual property

Participants retain ownership of the code and content they create during the event. By participating, you grant the organisers a non-exclusive right to display, describe and photograph your submission for the purpose of judging, publicity and reporting. Submissions must be your own original work created during the event; pre-built projects are not eligible for prizes.

7. Judging and prizes

Judging criteria are announced at the start of the event. Judges' decisions are final. Prizes are awarded at the organisers' discretion and may be withheld if participation rules are breached. Prize distribution timelines and any applicable taxes are the responsibility of the winner.

8. Code of conduct

Harassment, discrimination, plagiarism, damage to property, and use of prohibited substances are grounds for immediate removal without refund. Treat other participants, mentors, volunteers and staff with respect.

9. Media

Photography and video recording take place throughout the event. By attending you consent to your likeness being used in event coverage and promotional material by SNIST and StudentAlumni.ai. If you do not wish to be photographed, inform the registration desk at check-in.

10. Data

Personal data collected at registration is used to administer the event, issue certificates, and manage meals and access. Data may be shared with partners **only where you have given explicit consent** at registration. See Section 11 for retention. You may request deletion of your data by contacting the organisers.

11. Changes and cancellation

Organisers reserve the right to change the schedule, format, venue or prize structure, and to cancel the event in circumstances beyond their control. Material changes will be communicated to registered participants by email.

12. Liability

Participants attend at their own risk. Organisers are not liable for loss or damage to personal property, or for personal injury, except where caused by their negligence. Participants are responsible for their own equipment.

Section H — Operations runbook

H1. Roles

Role	Responsibility	Count ASSUMED
Event lead	Owns the run of show	1
Registration desk	Gate scanning, manual check-in, ID checks	4–6
Meal stations	Coupon scanning at counters	2–3 per counter
Tech/scanner support	Device issues, offline sync, network	2
Mentors	Floating technical help	Per plan
Judges	L2/L3 and final evaluation	Per plan
Media	Photo/video	2
Overnight duty	Security liaison, welfare through the night	2+

H2. Timeline

- **T-14 days** — Registration link live and promoted. Partner coupon batches requested. Scanner devices identified.
- **T-7 days** — L1 assessment window. Catering counts drafted from registrations.
- **T-48 hours** — Registration closes. Final headcount to catering. Allowlist generated. Volunteers briefed and given scanner logins.
- **T-24 hours** — Scanner devices tested on campus wifi *at the actual gate location*. Offline allowlist downloaded to each device. Signage printed.
- **Day 1, 06:30** — Desks set up, stations mode-configured, test scans run with dummy tickets.
- **Day 1, 08:00** — Gates open.
- **Through the event** — Meal windows opened and closed on schedule; live dashboards watched.
- **Day 2, 13:00** — Close. Certificates and rewards released.
- **T+3 days** — Partner redemption reports; feedback survey; data retention clock starts.

H3. Pre-event test checklist

- ☐ Register a test participant end to end and confirm the ticket appears in My Tickets
- ☐ Scan that ticket at gate mode — confirm `CHECKED_IN`
- ☐ Scan again — confirm amber "already used"
- ☐ Scan at meal mode — confirm the correct slot is consumed
- ☐ Scan the same meal again — confirm refusal
- ☐ Scan an invalid/forged QR — confirm red
- ☐ Turn off network mid-scan — confirm offline queue works and syncs
- ☐ Open a ticket on a low-end Android phone in daylight — confirm the QR scans
- ☐ Confirm a partner coupon reveals, copies, and opens the right URL

Section I — Data and privacy

- **Collect only what the event needs.** Every extra field is a liability and a drop-off point in the form.
- **Consent is granular.** Separate checkboxes for (a) event administration, (b) media, (c) sharing details with named partners. Partner sharing must be opt-in and must name the partners.
- **Retention.** Define a period — recommend 12 months for registration data, longer only for certificate verification records, which need to stay queryable.
- **Access control.** Volunteers see only the fields needed to check someone in — name, college, team, meal status. Not phone numbers or emails.
- **Secrets.** The QR signing key lives server-side only, never in the scanner client. Rotate after the event.
- **Minors.** If under-18 participants are permitted, guardian consent must be recorded at registration, not collected at the gate.

Section K — Hackathon challenges

Scope. Sections K through P govern the **hackathon** — the team build that runs inside the event. They do **not** govern the Codethon.
The **Codethon** is the pre-event track: **L1 → L2 → L3**, individually scored, **closing before the event goes live**. Its winners are decided on level reached and score, not on the rubric below, and it has no team-size rule, no build window, no GitHub or deployment requirement, and no live demo round. See Section A9 for the Codethon; see M-series below for the hackathon.

Teams pick **one** challenge track. All five are open to every team; the track is declared at submission.

K1. The five tracks

1 · AI That Solves a Real Problem Build an AI-powered application that solves a meaningful problem faced by individuals, businesses or communities. The problem should be genuine, and the solution should demonstrate how AI creates value beyond traditional software.

2 · Beyond the Chatbot Build an AI experience that moves past a traditional chat interface. Reimagine how people interact with AI — through automation, voice, visual interfaces, collaborative experiences, workflows, or entirely new interaction models.

3 · AI for Builders Build a tool that helps developers, designers, creators, researchers or other professionals work faster, better or more efficiently. Your solution should remove friction from an existing workflow using AI.

4 · Autonomous AI Workflows Build an application where AI independently completes a multi-step task by reasoning, planning, using tools, or coordinating multiple actions with minimal human intervention.

5 · Build the Unexpected Build something original that surprises the judges. Experimental, entertaining, technically ambitious or creatively executed — the goal is to showcase what can be built in a single day with AI.

K2. Mandatory open-source stack

> **Required.** You must use the open sources provided by the organisers during the event as part of your application. **Not using all the AI open sources provided by the event organisers is an instant disqualification** — this is not a scoring deduction, it is a hard fail.

DECIDE The exact list of provided open sources must be published to participants in writing before the build block starts, and repeated in the submission form. A disqualification rule this severe cannot rest on something announced verbally on the day.

K3. Anti-boring rules

Projects are penalised if they:

- Are single-prompt wrappers
- Use only static datasets
- Do not make decisions
- Lack system thinking

K4. What we're looking for

We want	Not
Systems	demos
Agents	prompts
Decisions	outputs
Real-world relevance	gimmicks

Section L — Participation rules

Dates need correcting before publishing. These are the hackathon rules, but as supplied they carry dates from the previous edition — *"Build by Sunset hackathon on July 31, 2026"*, build hours of *9:00 AM – 6:30 PM*, a *~8 hour* window, and a submission deadline of *6:30 PM on July 31, 2026*. HackWave 3.0 runs **Sep 4–5, 2026, 08:00 AM to 01:00 PM**. Every date, hour and deadline in Sections L and N must be restated against the HackWave schedule before this is published. DECIDE

The decision that matters most: **when does the build window open and close, and when do submissions shut?** The previous edition gave teams ~8 hours in one day. HackWave runs overnight, so the build window could be far longer — and the anti-boring bar, the two-round judging and the 15-team shortlist were all calibrated for the shorter format.

L1. Team size

- Minimum **2** members, maximum **5** members per team.
- Solo entries are not permitted for the hackathon. *(The Codethon is individual — see Section A9.)*

L2. Fresh ideas only — no pre-built projects

- All projects must be new and conceived specifically for this hackathon.
- You may not submit existing projects, fork existing codebases (beyond standard libraries and boilerplates), or continue work on personal projects already started.
- The spirit is to build something fresh.

L3. Start your engines at the event

- All project development — coding, asset creation, everything — must begin during the official hackathon hours. DECIDE ***confirm the hours against the Sep 4–5 schedule***

L4. Pre-hackathon planning is encouraged

- Coding starts at the event, but research, brainstorming and planning beforehand are strongly encouraged. Come with a concept.

L5. Innovate, don't replicate

- Direct clones of existing applications without significant innovation or a unique twist are strongly discouraged.
- **The goal:** this isn't about the most polished application. It's about trying genuinely new ideas, experimenting with novel mechanics, and using the build window to innovate with feedback from your peers. Ask yourself: *what new problem am I solving, or how am I solving an old problem in a radically new way?*

L6. Public and deployed

All submissions must be public and reviewable:

- A public GitHub repository
- A working demo link — deployed to Vercel, Netlify or any hosting platform the judges can review
- A 3-minute video demo

Your project must be deployed and operational for demonstration and review.

Section M — Judging

Judging runs in two rounds so every project gets a fair and thorough evaluation.

M1. Round 1 — AI-based evaluation

After submissions close, every project is evaluated by AI judges using the same scoring rubric shared with all participants. The AI judges review:

- GitHub repository
- Project documentation (README)
- Deployed application *(optional)*
- Demo video

This lets every submission be reviewed consistently at scale, against identical criteria.

The top 15 highest-scoring teams advance to the final round.

M2. Round 2 — Live demo and human judging

The shortlisted 15 teams present to the judging panel. Each team gets:

- **3 minutes** to demo

- **2 minutes** for Q&A from the judges

Judges evaluate the quality of the live demonstration, clarity of problem and solution, technical depth and engineering decisions, product thinking and user experience, and overall execution and potential.

Final winners are selected on the judges' evaluation during the live presentations, taking the project's overall quality and demonstration into account.

M3. Judging criteria

Both rounds use the same six criteria:

Criterion	The question being asked
Problem & Impact	Does the project solve a real and meaningful problem?
AI Implementation	Does AI play an important role, rather than being added for its own sake?
Technical Execution	Does it work reliably and demonstrate good engineering?
User Experience	Is it easy to use, intuitive and well-designed?
Innovation & Creativity	Is the idea original, or does it approach the problem in a unique way?
Demo & Presentation	Can the team clearly explain the project and demonstrate how it works?

DECIDE Publish the weighting and the point scale for these six criteria before submissions open. "The same rubric shared with all participants" only holds if participants actually have the numbers.

M4. Instant red flags

- Chatbot with no structure
- Static outputs regardless of input
- No visible reasoning
- UI-heavy, logic-light projects
- "Looks cool but does nothing meaningful"
- Static HTML pages or apps with no meaningful interactions
- **Not using all the AI open sources provided by the organisers — instant disqualification**

Section N — Submission requirements

Each team must submit:

- **Public GitHub repository**
- **Project README** explaining the problem, solution, setup and usage

- **Short demo video** (3 minutes)

Optional but highly recommended:

- **Live deployment**

A complete, well-documented submission makes it easier for both the AI judges and the human judges to understand and evaluate the project.

N1. Development rules

- All projects must be built within the hackathon timeframe.
- **GitHub commit history is mandatory.** Projects must show incremental progress — no single bulk push.
- Fully AI-generated projects with no meaningful human contribution are **not allowed**. Teams must demonstrate understanding and ownership of their code.

N2. Submission deadline

- All submissions must be completed before the official deadline.
- Submissions close **sharp** at the published time. DECIDE *the supplied rules say 6:30 PM on July 31, 2026; correct to the HackWave schedule*
- **Late submissions are not accepted under any circumstances.**

N3. Disqualification criteria

Teams may be disqualified for:

- Violating any rule in this handbook
- Plagiarism or using pre-built projects
- Lack of meaningful commit history
- Not being present for judging or demo
- Not using all provided AI open sources

Section O — Code of conduct

1. Purpose

We are committed to providing a safe, inclusive and respectful environment for all participants, regardless of background, identity or experience level.

This Code of Conduct applies to all attendees — participants, mentors, judges, sponsors, volunteers and organisers — across all hackathon spaces: physical venues, online platforms (Telegram, WhatsApp, codespectra.ai, submissions), and social events associated with the hackathon.

2. Expected behaviour

All participants are expected to treat others with respect, professionalism and empathy; communicate constructively and inclusively; be mindful of different perspectives and experiences; collaborate in good faith; and follow instructions from organisers and staff.

3. Unacceptable behaviour

Harassment and inappropriate behaviour will not be tolerated. This includes, but is not limited to:

Offensive verbal or written comments relating to gender, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, disability, physical appearance or body size, race, ethnicity, nationality, religion or beliefs.

Sexual content or behaviour — unwelcome sexual attention; sexualised images, language or materials in public spaces; creating a sexualised environment.

Abusive or harmful actions — intimidation, threats or coercion; stalking or following; deliberate disruption of talks, demos or events; inappropriate physical contact.

Privacy violations — recording (photo, audio, video) without consent; sharing private information without permission; taking photos where privacy is expected, such as restrooms.

Online misconduct — harassment via chat platforms or submissions; spam, trolling or hostile behaviour; posting offensive or inappropriate content.

4. Photography and media

Photography and recording are generally allowed. **If someone objects to being recorded or photographed, their request must be respected immediately.**

5. Project and content guidelines

All submissions must comply with this Code of Conduct. Projects must not promote hate, discrimination or violence; include explicit, sexualised or offensive content; violate privacy or misuse personal data; or infringe intellectual property without attribution.

6. Sponsor and partner conduct

Sponsors, partners and their representatives are also subject to this Code of Conduct. They must not use sexualised or inappropriate imagery, materials or branding; create uncomfortable or exclusionary environments; or engage in aggressive, misleading or exploitative behaviour.

7. Reporting issues

If you experience or witness any violation:

- Contact the organising team immediately, via the designated channels or in-person staff.
- You may report anonymously if needed.

Organisers will take all reports seriously, respond promptly and confidentially, and provide support — including contacting security or authorities if necessary.

DECIDE Name the reporting channel explicitly before the event: a phone number, a named person, and an anonymous form link. A reporting process that says "contact the organising team" without naming how is a process people won't use when they most need it.

8. Enforcement

Participants asked to stop any inappropriate behaviour are expected to comply immediately. Organisers reserve the right to take appropriate action, including verbal or written warnings, removal from the hackathon (without refund, if applicable), disqualification of projects, and a ban from future events.

9. Scope

This Code of Conduct applies to all hackathon activities, workshops and sessions, online interactions, and social and networking events related to the hackathon.

10. Final note

We are here to build, learn and push boundaries — not at the cost of someone else's safety or dignity. By participating, you agree to uphold this Code of Conduct and contribute to a respectful, inclusive environment for everyone.

Section P — Housekeeping and venue

P1. Personal belongings

- Participants are responsible for their own belongings.
- Organisers are not liable for loss or damage.

P2. Workspace etiquette

- Keep your desk and surrounding area clean and organised.
- Do not damage venue property.

P3. Damage policy

- Any damage to venue property will result in penalties or fines.
- Participants will be held accountable for misuse.

P4. Food and cleanliness

- **No food inside the designated hacking space.**
- Use the designated eating areas only.
- Designated eating areas and the on-site **food stalls** are the places to eat.

Overnight coverage. The meal design (Section E) runs a 00:30 slot, and the food ban applies to the hacking space throughout. Make sure the eating area and at least one stall are signposted and staffed through the night, or the rule gets ignored at 1 AM and food ends up on the desks anyway.

Section Q — Using CodeSpectra: teams and submissions

Platform: **codespectra.ai**. This section covers how participants join a team and submit their GitHub URL. It is the most-asked-about part of any hackathon, so publish it to participants as a standalone guide too, not just inside this handbook.

Blocking conflict — team size. CodeSpectra caps teams at **4 members, captain included**, and shows a `x/4` counter on the team card. Section L1 of this handbook sets the hackathon team size at **2–5**. A five-person team physically cannot join on the platform. Either raise the platform cap to 5, or drop the published rule to 4. This must be settled before registration opens — not on the morning of the event, with a fifth member standing at the desk. DECIDE

Q1. Before you start

Requirement	Notes
A CodeSpectra account	Sign in at codespectra.ai **before** opening any invite link
A GitHub account	Your solution repo lives here
Your team's invite link **or** the event link	Sent by your captain or the organisers
A working repo	Public, or accessible to the judging team

Tip worth repeating at the desk. Sign in *first*, then click the invite link. Opening an invite while logged out is the single most common reason a join fails.

Q2. Joining as a team

If you are the captain

1. Open the hackathon event page.
2. Create your team and name it. You become the **Captain**, marked on the team card.
3. The card shows **team name · members (x/4) · submissions count**.

4. Scroll to the **Invite Teammates** panel.

Inviting teammates — two options

- **Share the join link** — `https://codespectra.ai/hackathons/<event-slug>/join/<invite-token>`. Use the copy icon, share on WhatsApp, Slack or email.
- **Send invite by email** — click *Send invite by email* and enter the address; CodeSpectra delivers it.

If you are joining an existing team

1. Log in to CodeSpectra.
2. Click the join link your captain shared.
3. You are added and the member counter updates (1/4 → 2/4).
4. You get the same dashboard as your captain: problems, countdown, leaderboard.

Q3. Before the event goes live

While the event is **UPCOMING**, the dashboard shows a countdown, the full problem list (difficulty, points, and whether each is *Required*), **View Problem** links, and the leaderboard. **Submit buttons stay hidden until the event begins.**

Use that window to:

- ☐ Confirm every teammate has joined — check the x/4 counter
- ☐ Read every problem statement via **View Problem**
- ☐ Create the GitHub repo and confirm the judges can open it
- ☐ Read the Rules & Regulations tab

Q4. During the event

When the countdown hits zero the header switches to **Event is LIVE** with a time-remaining timer, and each problem row gains three actions:

Action	What it does
View Problem	Opens the full problem statement
Claim	Marks that a teammate is working on it — prevents duplicate effort
Submit Solution	Opens the submission form

Recommended flow: captain assigns problems → each member **Claims** theirs → work → submit.

Q5. Submitting your solution

The submission form has four fields:

Field	Required?	Format	Example
Repo URL	Optional*	Full GitHub URL	`https://github.com/<user>/<repo>`
Commit SHA	Optional	Short SHA or full commit URL	`abc1234`
Language	Yes	Dropdown	`Python`
Code	Yes*	Paste your solution into the editor	—

* Marked optional in the form, but a submission is only meaningfully judged if it carries **either** a working repo URL **or** pasted code. Best practice is both.

Getting the GitHub URL

1. Open your repository on github.com.
2. Copy the plain repo URL from the address bar — `https://github.com/<user>/<repo>`.
3. **Do not** paste the `/tree/main`, `/compare` or `/pull/...` variants.
4. Paste it into **Repo URL**.

Getting the commit SHA (recommended)

Pinning a commit tells judges exactly which version to grade, so a later push can't break your score.

1. Click the **Commits** counter on your repo.
2. Use the copy icon next to the commit you want judged.
3. Paste the 7-character short SHA into **Commit SHA**. A full commit URL also works.

Then submit

Select the **Language**, paste your solution into the **Code** editor, click **Submit**. A toast confirms *"Solution submitted! Your submission is being reviewed."* The row then shows a **Submitted** badge and a **View Submission** button. Repeat for every problem marked **Required** — the team isn't finished until each one shows Submitted.

Q6. Repo access checklist

- ☐ Repo is **public**, or organiser and judge accounts are added as collaborators
- ☐ The default branch contains the final code
- ☐ A `README.md` exists — it is directly worth marks (Section M3)
- ☐ The last commit is **pushed**, not just committed locally
- ☐ The URL opens in a private/incognito window

> **A private repo with no judge access scores the same as no submission.** Check this before the timer runs out, not after.

Q7. Platform rules

- **Scoring** — points are awarded on test cases passed and code quality.
- **The last submission counts.** Never leave a broken final submission on the clock.
- **Unlimited submissions** during the event window. Submit early, submit often, refine as you go.
- Submissions close the moment the timer expires.
- **Plagiarism or collusion between teams is disqualification.**

> **Reconcile with Section M.** Section M describes two-round judging on a six-criteria rubric with a top-15 shortlist and live demos; this platform section describes per-problem scoring on test cases and code quality, with the last submission counting. Both can be true if the platform handles submission intake and the rubric handles evaluation — but participants will read them as contradictory unless you say which applies to what, in writing. DECIDE

Q8. Quick reference

Captain — create team → copy join link → share with teammates → assign problems → confirm every required problem shows **Submitted**.

Member — log in → open join link → **Claim** your problem → push to GitHub → **Submit Solution** with repo URL, commit SHA, language and code.

Submission form, in one line: `Repo URL` → `Commit SHA` → `Language` → `Code` → **Submit**

Section J — Open decisions

These are the items that block build. Grouped by who needs to answer.

You / SNIST CDC

1. Team registration model and team size limits
2. Registration close date and walk-in quota
3. Whether certificates require check-in
4. Whether a photo is captured at registration for identity verification
5. Meal slots and windows (Section E1 is my proposal)
6. Whether judges/mentors/volunteers get tickets in the same system

Partners

1. Coupon redemption model per partner (Section F2)
2. Coupon batch sizes, eligibility and expiry dates
3. **Spelling: StepUpMark AI vs SetupMark AI** — your LinkedIn copy and your MoU disagree

Blocking — hackathon rules and judging *(the Codethon is governed separately: L1 → L2 → L3, scored, closing before the event)*

1. **Hackathon build window and submission deadline.** The rules carry the previous edition's dates (July 31, 2026, 9:00 AM – 6:30 PM, ~8 hours). Restate every date, hour and deadline in Sections L and N against the Sep 4–5 schedule — and decide whether the overnight format means a longer build window than the ~8 hours the rubric was calibrated for.
2. **The provided open-source list** must be published in writing before the build starts — it carries an instant-disqualification penalty.
3. Rubric weighting and point scale for the six judging criteria, published before submissions open.
4. Named reporting channel for Code of Conduct issues — person, number, and anonymous form.
5. Who staffs the eating area and food stalls overnight, given food is banned from the hacking space.
6. Whether any partner or sponsor coupon is redeemable at the on-site food stalls.
7. **Team size vs the platform cap.** CodeSpectra caps teams at 4 members; the published rule says 2–5. Raise the cap or lower the rule — before registration opens.
8. Which scoring model participants are told applies where: CodeSpectra's per-problem test-case scoring, or the six-criteria rubric with the top-15 live-demo round.

Product/engineering

1. Rotating QR — yes or no, and for which scan types
2. Apple Wallet / Google Wallet passes — in scope for v1?
3. Which channel carries the ticket besides email — WhatsApp, SMS, both
4. Where reward unlock timing is configured — hardcoded or admin-editable

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